

Notes from a Quiet Café

Book 5 of 10

Every morning, a note on his table. But no one ever sees who leaves them.

CEFR Level A1 | Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A small café in Edinburgh. A corner table by the window.

Genre: Quiet Mystery / Warm Drama

Characters

- Tom - 29. Freelance writer. Works in the café every morning.

- Hana - 27. A graphic designer. Comes before Tom - but leaves before he notices her.

- Mari - 60. The café owner. Observant and warm.

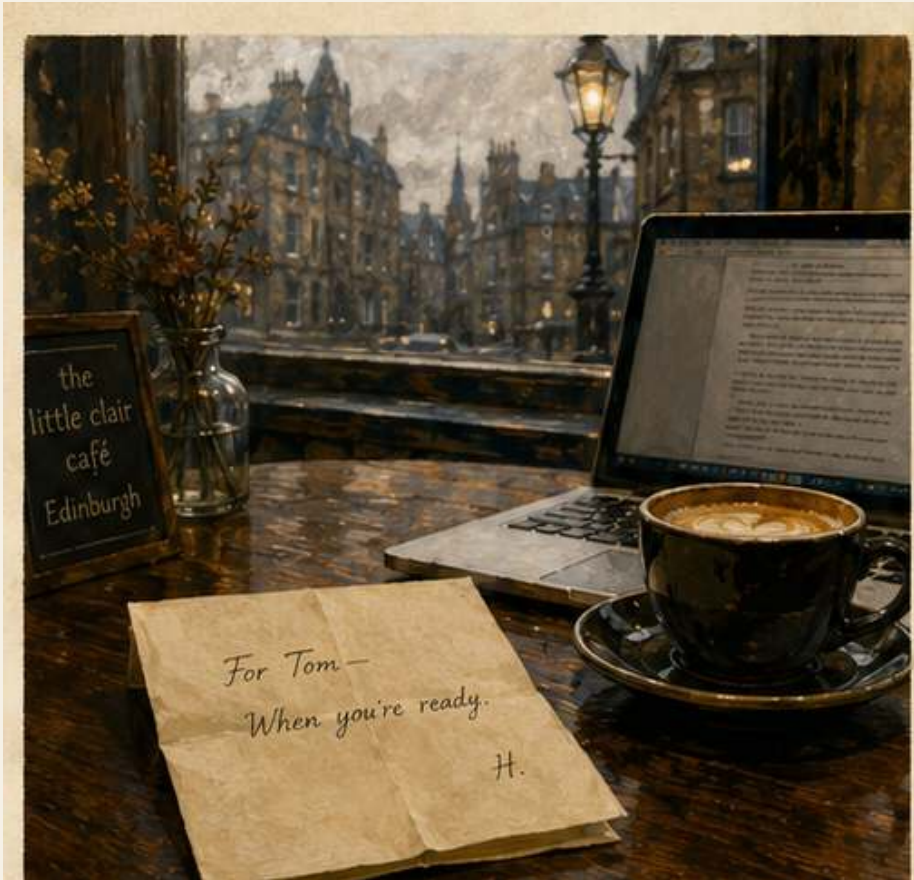
Notes from a Quiet Café

Tom comes to the café every morning at eight thirty. He orders a large flat white and sits at the corner table near the window. He opens his laptop. He writes. Or tries to write. The café is quiet. There are only a few customers. They read. They type. They look at their phones. This morning, he sits down - and sees something on the table. A small piece of paper. Folded in half.

Tom opens the note. The handwriting is small and neat. "The light here is very good in the morning. Best at nine fifteen. Look up from your screen." Tom looks up. The light from the window is warm and golden on the wooden floor. He looks around. Nobody is watching him. He looks at the note again. He does not know who wrote it.

The next morning: no note. Tom sits down, orders his coffee, opens his laptop. At nine o'clock he goes to the counter for sugar. He is away from the table for one minute. When he comes back - there is a note. He looks around quickly. Nobody moves. Nobody looks at him. "You always order the same coffee. Do you like it, or is it just a habit?"

Notes from a Quiet Café



A folded note appears on Tom's café table.

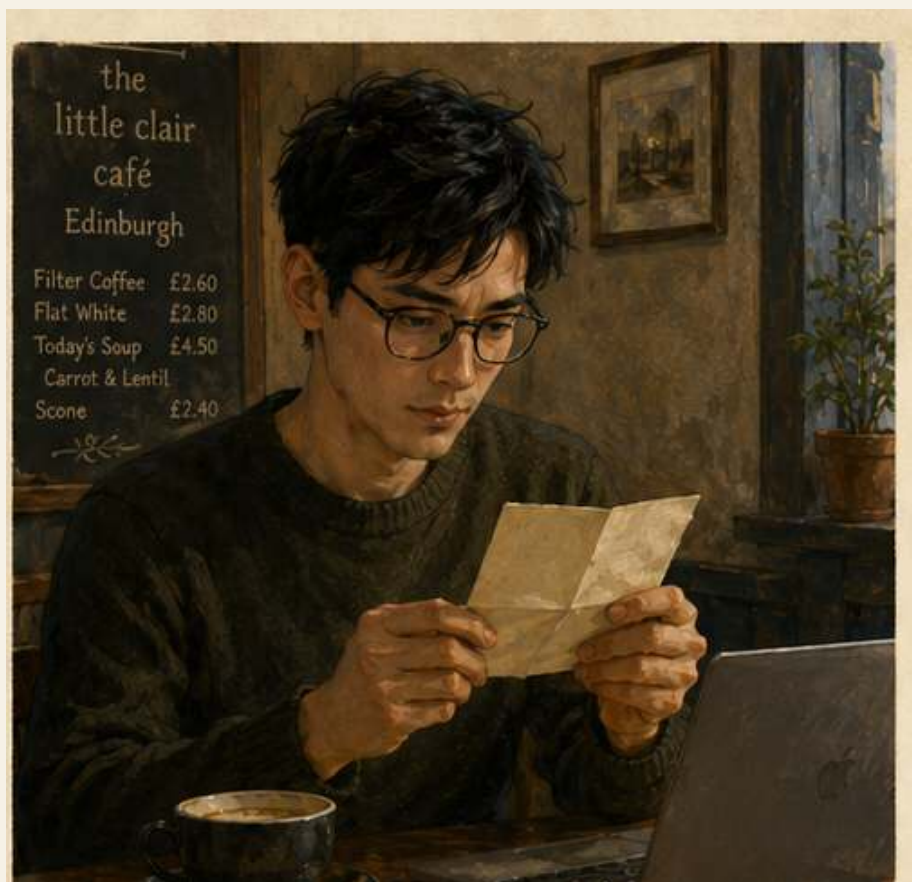
Tom takes the note to the counter. 'Mari, do you know who is leaving these notes on my table?' Mari looks at the note. She reads it. She smiles - a small smile. 'I cannot say.' 'Cannot or will not?' Tom asks. Mari goes back to the coffee machine. 'More coffee?' she asks. She is not going to tell him.

Tom watches carefully all week. The notes always appear when he is away from the table. Monday - he goes to the toilet. One minute. Note. Tuesday - he goes to the counter for water. Thirty seconds. Note. Wednesday - he looks out of the window. Five seconds. Note. Someone is very quick. Someone is very close. But Tom cannot see anyone put the note there. It is like a small, friendly ghost.

Thursday. Tom is at his table and does not move. He waits. Nothing. At nine o'clock a woman comes in - dark coat, bag full of papers. She orders coffee, sits next to Tom, and works. At nine fifteen she stands up and goes to the counter. Tom looks away for one second. When he looks back - there is a note.

Tom opens the note: 'Your face is very serious when you write. It is not a bad thing. It means you

Notes from a Quiet Café



Tom reads the note with curiosity.

care.' Tom looks at the counter. The woman is paying. Her back is to him. She has short dark hair. She is young - maybe late twenties. She takes her coffee to go. She walks to the door. She does not look back. 'Excuse me-' Tom says. But she is already outside. The door closes.

Friday morning. Tom arrives at seven fifty - early. He waits. At eight fifteen the woman comes in. She does not look at Tom. She orders her coffee. She sits - not next to him today. Across the room. At eight forty-five she leaves. Tom does not move. He does not go anywhere. No note. He smiles to himself. So it is definitely her.

After the woman leaves, Tom goes to the counter. 'Her name. Please.' Mari thinks. 'She is a regular. She comes every morning before you - at seven fifty. She always leaves before nine.' 'She knows my schedule?' Mari smiles. 'She noticed you first,' she says. 'Her name?' Mari is quiet. Then: 'Hana. Her name is Hana.' Tom says thank you. Mari goes back to the coffee machine. She looks pleased.

That afternoon, Tom writes a note carefully. He folds it. The next morning, he arrives at seven forty - before Hana. He puts the note on the table

next to his - the table where Hana usually sits. He goes to the corner table. He opens his laptop. He waits. At seven fifty, Hana walks in.

Hana orders her coffee. She walks to her usual table. She sees the note. She stops. She picks it up and reads it. Tom watches from the corner of his eye. Hana's face is still. Then - a small smile. She looks around the café. Her eyes find Tom. Tom looks back at her. Neither of them speaks. Hana sits down. She puts the note in her bag.

Tom's note said: "I know it is you. Thank you for the notes. They helped more than you know. The one about the light was the best. My name is Tom. If you want to know what I write - ask me." Hana reads it again. She writes a reply on a small piece of paper. When Tom goes to the counter for his flat white, she puts the reply on his table. It says: 'What do you write?'

Tom writes back immediately: "Short stories. About people in cafés. People who sit alone and think and feel things. I have been writing one about a woman who leaves notes for a man she does not know. I don't know how it ends yet. Can I ask you something? Why did you start leaving notes? Hana reads the reply. She looks up. Tom is

watching her. She picks up her pen.

Hana's answer comes while Tom is at the counter: "Because you looked lonely. Not sad - just alone. And the café is full of people who are alone together. I thought: one note. Something small. But then you looked up and saw the light. And I thought: he sees things. He is a writer. I wanted to see if you would notice." 'He noticed,' Tom writes. 'Can we talk properly? Just once?'

Hana's final note: 'Tomorrow. Saturday. Ten o'clock. The big table in the middle. It is time to talk properly.' Tom smiles the whole afternoon and does not write one word. On Saturday at ten, Tom is at the big table. At ten past ten, Hana walks in. She has no bag of papers. She looks lighter. 'Hello,' she says. 'Hello,' Tom says. 'Sit down.'

They talk for two hours. Hana is a graphic designer. She loves typography and colour. Tom tells her about his stories. Most are not published. 'Not yet,' he says. Hana laughs. 'Not yet is good. It means you still believe.' Tom likes this. He writes it in his notebook. Hana sees him. 'Am I in your notebook now?' 'Maybe,' Tom says. She smiles.

Notes from a Quiet Café



Tom and Hana finally meet in the café.

That evening, Tom opens his laptop and writes a short story. It is about a woman who leaves notes for a man in a café. He writes it in two hours - the fastest he has ever written. When he reads it back, it is good. He knows it is good. He does not change anything. He sends it to a small literary magazine. Then he makes tea and looks at all five notes on the table.

Six weeks later, the magazine accepts the story. Tom calls Hana. 'They took it.' Hana is quiet. Then: 'I knew they would.' 'How?' 'Because I was there when you wrote it. You had a different face.' 'A different face?' 'Yes. Not serious this time. Happy.' Tom smiles. He does not know what to say. So he says: 'Thank you.'

The story is published in October. Tom buys three copies of the magazine. He gives one to Mari. She puts it behind the counter in a visible place. 'You are my famous writer now.' Tom laughs. He gives the second copy to Hana. She reads it that evening and calls him at ten o'clock. 'Tom. She is not lonely at the end.' 'No,' Tom says. 'She is not.'

In November, Tom still comes to the café at eight thirty. But now, three mornings a week,

Hana comes at eight thirty too. They sit at the corner table. They do not always talk - sometimes Tom writes, sometimes Hana draws. But they are there. At the same table. In the same good light. On the table: always one flat white and one black coffee. Mari brings them without asking. She knows their order. She always knew.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. corner table	köşe masası	2. flat white	sütlü espresso
3. laptop	dizüstü bilgisayar	4. customers	müşteriler
5. folded in half	ikiye katlanmış	6. handwriting	el yazısı
7. neat	düzgün	8. angle	açı
9. golden	altın sarısı	10. nobody	hiç kimse
11. sugar	şeker	12. away from	uzakta
13. quickly	hızlıca	14. same	aynı
15. habit	alışkanlık	16. sharp eyes	keskin gözler
17. leaving	bırakan	18. cannot say	söyleyemem
19. will not	söylemeyecek	20. pattern	kalıp, düzen
21. appears	belirir	22. seconds	saniyeler
23. close	yakın	24. ghost	hayalet
25. next to	yanında	26. obvious	belli, açık
27. looks away	bakışlarını çevirir	28. looks back	tekrar bakar
29. serious	ciddi	30. care	önemsemek
31. back is to him	sırtı ona dönük	32. to go	paket, götürmek için
33. already	çoktan	34. early	erken

35. across the room	odanın karşısında	36. definitely	kesinlikle
37. smiles to himself	kendi kendine gülümser	38. regular	düzenli müşteri
39. schedule	program	40. noticed	fark etti
41. first	önce	42. pleased	memnun
43. carefully	dikkatle	44. usually sits	genellikle oturur
45. waits	bekler	46. afternoon	öğleden sonra
47. corner of his eye	göz ucuyla	48. still	hareketsiz
49. neither of them	hiçbiri	50. takes out	çıkartır
51. helped	yardımcı oldu	52. best	en iyi
53. ask me	bana sor	54. reply	yanıt
55. immediately	hemen	56. short stories	kısa hikâyeler
57. ends	bitiyor	58. yet	henüz
59. lonely	yalnız	60. full of	... ile dolu
61. together	birlikte	62. properly	düzgünce
63. final	son	64. middle	orta
65. lighter	daha hafif, rahatlamış	66. ten past ten	onu on geçiyor
67. graphic designer	grafik tasarımcı	68. typography	tipografi
69. published	yayımlanmış	70. believe	inanmak
71. notebook	defter	72. fastest he has ever	written

73. şimdiye kadar yazdığı en hızlı	literary magazine	74. edebiyat dergisi	sends
75. gönderir	He sends the story. Five notes on the table. They are his.	76. accepts	kabul eder
77. I knew they would	alacaklarını biliyordum	78. different face	farklı bir yüz
79. happy	mutlu	80. published	yayımlandı
81. copies	nüshalar	82. visible place	görünür yer
83. famous	ünlü	84. at the end	sonunda
85. still goes	hâlâ gidiyor	86. three mornings a week	haftada üç sabah
87. always knew	hep biliyordu	88. draws	çizer

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice - Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

1. neat
- A. düzgün
2. habit
- B. alışkanlık
3. obvious
- C. belli, açık
4. schedule
- D. yalnız
5. lonely
- E. program
6. properly
- F. düzgünce
7. published
- G. yayımlanmış
8. believe
- H. inanmak

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

note - lonely - light - habit - properly - published

1. Tom finds a folded _____ on his table one morning.
2. The first note says: the _____ here is very good at nine fifteen.
3. Hana starts leaving notes because Tom looks _____.
4. Tom always orders the same coffee - Hana asks if it is just a _____.

5. They agree to talk _____ on Saturday.

6. Tom's story is _____ in October.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Tom comes to the café every afternoon. ____

2. The notes appear when Tom is away from the table. ____

3. Mari is the café owner. ____

4. Hana is a doctor. ____

5. Tom sends his story to a newspaper. ____

6. The magazine accepts the story. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. What does the first note say?

8. How does Tom discover it is Hana leaving the notes?

9. What is Tom's job?

10. What is Hana's job?

11. What does Tom write in his note to Hana?

12. Why did Hana start leaving notes?

13. What story does Tom write after he meets Hana properly?

14. What does Mari do with the magazine?

15. How does the story end for Tom and Hana?

Answer Key

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-A 2-B 3-C 4-E 5-D 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. note 2. light 3. lonely 4. habit 5. properly 6. published

True / False: 1. F 2. T 3. T 4. F 5. F 6. T

7. The light is very good in the morning - best at nine fifteen. Look up from your screen.

8. When he arrives early and Hana sits across the room, no note appears.

9. He is a freelance writer.

10. She is a graphic designer.

11. He says he knows it is her, thanks her for the notes, and asks what he writes.

12. Because Tom looked lonely and she wanted to give him something small.

13. A short story about a woman who leaves notes for a man in a café.

14. She puts it behind the counter in a visible place.

15. They now come to the café together three mornings a week.